



Food Allergen Awareness — Employee Training Guide

Food allergies affect millions of people and can cause reactions ranging from mild discomfort to a life-threatening emergency. Understanding allergens and how to prevent cross-contact is one of the most important parts of your job — a small mistake can seriously harm a customer. Please read this guide carefully.

The Major Food Allergens (the "Big 9")

These 9 foods cause the vast majority of serious allergic reactions and must be clearly identified on food labels and menus where required.

Milk

Eggs

Fish

Shellfish

Tree Nuts

Peanuts

Wheat

Soybeans

Sesame

Recognizing an Allergic Reaction

MILD SYMPTOMS

Itching or tingling in the mouth · Hives or skin rash · Mild swelling · Stomach discomfort

SEVERE SYMPTOMS (ANAPHYLAXIS — MEDICAL EMERGENCY)

Difficulty breathing or swallowing · Swelling of the throat, tongue, or face · Dizziness or fainting · Rapid or weak pulse

Cross-Contact: What It Is and How to Prevent It

Cross-contact happens when an allergen unintentionally transfers to a food that isn't supposed to contain it — even in a tiny, invisible amount. Unlike cross-contamination from bacteria, cross-contact cannot be cooked or washed away once it happens.

- Wash your hands and change gloves before handling a different order
- Use clean, separate utensils, cutting boards, and equipment for allergen-friendly orders
- Never reuse fryer oil between allergen and non-allergen items
- Clean and sanitize all surfaces between orders
- Store allergen ingredients separately, away from other food
- Read ingredient labels every time — recipes and products can change without notice

When a Customer Tells You They Have an Allergy

1. Take every allergy seriously, no matter how minor it sounds
2. Notify your manager or the kitchen immediately
3. Know your menu — be able to answer, or find out, what's in each dish
4. Never guess — check the ingredient list or ask the kitchen directly
5. Clearly communicate to the kitchen which allergen must be avoided
6. Use a dedicated, clean prep area and utensils for the order
7. Confirm with the customer before serving

In Case of a Reaction (Emergency Response)

- Recognize the signs of a severe reaction (see above)
- Call 911 immediately if you suspect anaphylaxis
- If the customer has their own epinephrine auto-injector and needs help, follow their instructions or your establishment's emergency procedure
- Stay with the person until help arrives
- Notify your manager right away
- Document the incident according to your establishment's procedure

When in doubt, don't guess — ask. It's always better to take a moment to check than to risk a customer's health.

By signing below, I acknowledge that I have received and understood this training on food allergen awareness.

EMPLOYEE NAME

SIGNATURE

DATE